to preserve across the desert?

But Humayun was a guest in Umarkot – more bluntly, a refugee – and guests cannot do as they please. Rana Prasad had helped Humayun because the rana wanted vengeance against Shah Husain of Sindh, whose territory Humayun had fled in such humiliating circumstances. Shah Husain had killed Rana Prasad's father, and the rana was willing to give Humayun troops, shelter and an alliance, if Humayun would help him obtain the shah's head.[50] Thus, on 11 October 1542, Humayun left Hamida and marched off with Rana Prasad towards Shah Husain's territory.

Humayun had to leave, but he left behind some instructions that reveal his keen interest in his prospective progeny. The emperor better known for his interest in astrology than in rule issued clear commands to Maulana Chand, his astrologer: be present at the birth and make precise note of the planets and stars that would reveal the newborn's fate.

Maulana Chand was nothing if not conscious of his responsibility, and zealous in discharging it. Not for him a merely clerical recording of the birth; he went above and beyond the call of duty and determined a wonderfully auspicious hour for it, too, 'such as does not happen once in a thousand years'. When Hamida went into labour some hours before this time, Maulana Chand was appalled. Not only was this not the best time to be born, it was, in fact, the worst. The astrologer hurried to the harem declaring, 'What an advantage if the birth could be delayed!'[51]

One can imagine how the women 'made light of' his idea, but little did they know. Fate had decided to favour the unborn child. A midwife arrived to deliver the baby; she was so utterly 'repulsive' that Hamida's contractions stopped in their tracks. Still, the astrologer's anxieties were not at an end. As night descended on Umarkot and the auspicious hour crept upon them, Hamida was fast asleep. Maulana Chand was 'disturbed', wishing perhaps to prod the girl awake. Again, her attendants were intractable. Hamida had fallen asleep 'after much suffering,' they said, and they would certainly not wake her. 'Whatever Almighty God . . . has determined, must happen.'

God was of one mind with the maulana. Hamida's attendants were still arguing with the astrologer when she woke up in labour. Just a little past 1 a.m. that night, on Sunday, 15 October 1542, not a moment too soon nor a